

A CONSUMER BEHAVIOR ANALYSIS OF REMA 1000

An analysis of consumer decision-making across milk, beer, coffee, and the REMA 1000 app

MAB1

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This paper examines how consumer behavior theory applies to everyday grocery shopping at REMA 1000, analyzing four product categories (milk, beer, coffee, and the REMA 1000 app) through the lens of a representative customer persona, Kristian Eriksen.

Kristian is a 37-year-old father of two in Bergen who values efficiency, balanced nutrition, and value for money. His shopping behavior reflects the routines and trade-offs typical of time-constrained family households, making him a useful lens for understanding decision-making in a discount grocery context. The four categories were chosen because they span different levels of involvement, regulation, and symbolic weight, from the highly habitual milk purchase to the socially visible beer selection.

ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK

The Paper Is Organized Around Three Behavioral Dimensions

□

INTERNAL INFLUENCES
Examines how sensory perception, learning, memory, motivation, and perceived risk shape product evaluation. Explores Oatly's brand knowledge through cognitive learning and classical conditioning. Proposes an olfactory strategy for Bergen Kaffebrenneri to increase trial through scent-based quality signaling at the shelf.

⚖️

ATTITUDES & DECISIONS
Applies the Elaboration Likelihood Model to an Evergood campaign, showing reliance on peripheral cues for low-involvement coffee purchases. Uses dual-process theory to assess when System 1 versus System 2 dominates across all four categories. Illustrates how compensatory and non-compensatory decision rules yield different outcomes in beer selection.

□

BEING & BELONGING
Analyzes how product choices express personal and social identity, from milk as parental responsibility to beer as taste signaling and coffee as community belonging. Examines the REMA 1000 app as a vehicle for brand loyalty and value alignment. Proposes a social norm intervention to nudge coffee purchasing behavior through descriptive norms.

KEY FINDINGS

Insights Across Categories

1

Sensory cues reduce uncertainty. Olfactory engagement at the coffee shelf bridges the gap between premium pricing and perceived quality, encouraging first-time trial of Bergen Kaffebrenneri.

2

Habit dominates routine purchases. Milk and everyday coffee default to System 1 processing driven by brand familiarity, price heuristics, and predictable shelf placement.

3

Context shifts the cognitive system. Beer for a dinner party and app adoption activate System 2, with consumers applying weighted additive, conjunctive, or lexicographic decision rules.

4

Social norms can nudge behavior. A descriptive norm campaign for Bergen Kaffebrenneri coffee can shift purchasing in low-involvement settings by highlighting peer behavior and community belonging.

CONCLUSION

Implications for REMA 1000 and Its Brand Partners

Together, these analyses demonstrate that even in a standardized discount retail environment, consumer decisions are shaped by a rich interplay of perception, cognition, identity, and social influence. Most grocery purchases are fast, automatic, and guided by simple heuristics, yet meaningful shifts toward deliberate processing occur when social visibility, financial stakes, or personal values become salient.

For REMA 1000, this means that store layout, shelf design, and digital touchpoints such as the app are not merely operational features but active shapers of consumer behavior. For the brands within its assortment, sensory interventions, well-framed normative messages, and identity-resonant positioning offer concrete pathways to influence choice without relying on traditional advertising. The paper provides actionable strategies grounded in established consumer behavior frameworks, each tailored to the regulatory, competitive, and psychological dynamics of its respective category.



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INTRODUCTION

RETAIL BRAND

REMA 1000: A Brief History

Founded in 1979 and part of the Reitan Retail Group, REMA 1000 has become one of Scandinavia's leading discount grocery chains through a standardized store format, franchised ownership model, and a strong emphasis on cost efficiency and simplicity. The chain operates over 680 stores across Norway, each following a uniform layout designed to reduce operational complexity and keep prices low. REMA 1000's franchise model empowers local store owners while maintaining centralized purchasing and branding. Its philosophy, "the simplest is often the best," extends to a curated, limited assortment strategy that reduces consumer decision fatigue and supports quick, habitual shopping. These features make REMA 1000 a highly relevant setting for analyzing everyday consumer decision-making.

FOUNDED 1979	PARENT GROUP Reitan Retail	STORES 680+ in Norway	MODEL Franchise
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CUSTOMER SEGMENT & PERSONA

Meet Kristian Eriksen



Kristian Eriksen is a 37-year-old married father of two young children living in Ytre Sandviken, Bergen. He works full-time in the public sector and is part of a middle-class, dual-income household. He holds a bachelor's degree and maintains structured routines that require high coordination across work, school, and family life.

AGE 37 years old	LOCATION Ytre Sandviken, Bergen	FAMILY Married, 2 children
OCCUPATION Public sector	EDUCATION Bachelor's degree	INCOME Dual-income, middle-class

Kristian Eriksen

Kristian values stability, efficiency, and balanced nutrition for his family. He prioritizes value for money rather than the lowest price. He prefers familiar, trustworthy brands, accepts private labels when quality is good enough, and is willing to pay slightly more for convenience or healthier options that make his everyday life easier and better. Kristian enjoys a good cup of coffee, and is therefore willing to spend a bit extra on good quality coffee.

Kristian's Preferences

- Value for money
- Brand loyalty
- Family nutrition
- Efficiency
- Convenience

PRODUCT CATEGORIES

Four Categories, Four Consumer Contexts

This report examines four product categories within the REMA 1000 ecosystem (beer, coffee, milk, and the REMA 1000 app), each shaped by different regulatory environments, competitive dynamics, and consumer decision-making processes. Together, they illustrate how consumer behavior theory applies across varied retail contexts.

 Beer REGULATED Alcoholic beer purchases in Norway are subject to strict sales and marketing regulations that limit the role of traditional advertising and sale hours. As a result, consumer decisions rely heavily on prior learning, brand recognition, packaging cues, and availability during limited sales windows. However, non-alcoholic beer sales are increasing and can be advertised more freely, provided they have a distinct brand and cannot reasonably be perceived as alcoholic beverages.	 Coffee PREMIUM RANGE Coffee is a category with high variety and price dispersion, ranging from low-cost private labels to premium local brands. This creates a setting in which sensory cues, perceived quality, and learned associations play a key role in guiding consumer choice.	 Milk ALTERNATIVES The milk category is characterized by a duopoly dominated by Tine and Q-meieriene, with strong brand similarity in packaging and pricing. This increases reliance on habitual choice, brand trust, and perceived risk reduction, particularly in family households. There are also non-dairy alternatives, such as plant-based and soy-based varieties, with Oatly and Alpro being the largest players.	 App DIGITAL The REMA 1000 app is widely used in Norway and offers customers cashback programs, personalized offers based on purchase history, and other features. The app is used before and during shopping trips, allowing customers to access offers and other information in different stages of their decision-making process. As a result, the app plays an important role in shaping customers' decision-making in REMA 1000 stores.
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SENSORY MARKETING AND PERCEPTION

01

Assignment 1: Internal Influences on Consumer Decisions

Perception · Learning & Memory · Motivation

SENSORY MARKETING & LOW INVOLVEMENT

Sensory marketing influences consumer decision-making by shaping how products are perceived in-store. In grocery retail, where decisions are made under time pressure and low to moderate involvement, sensory cues guide attention and influence product evaluation without extensive cognitive processing.

IN-STORE DYNAMICS

How Sensory Marketing Influences Consumer In-Store Decisions

At the point of purchase and during product familiarization, the brain tends to prioritize visual information over other sensory inputs, making visual cues (labels, packaging, color, placement) important factors that strongly shape perception and purchasing decisions (Posner et al., 1976). In addition, olfaction is also a powerful sensory cue due to its strong association with emotion and memory (Kivioja, 2017). In categories such as coffee, olfactory cues can signal freshness and quality, shape consumers' perceptions, and reduce perceived risk.

Visual stimuli, including color contrasts, packaging design, and shelf placement, play a central role in capturing attention. In REMA 1000's standardized store environment, visually distinctive products become especially salient.

By limiting assortment and maintaining consistent layouts, REMA 1000 reduces sensory overload. This supports selective attention and enables quick, low-effort decisions based on familiar cues.



EXPOSURE

Consumers must first be exposed to sensory stimuli before perception can occur. In grocery stores, exposure is shaped by shelf placement, packaging visibility, and the overall store environment, determining which products enter the consumer's perceptual field.



SELECTIVE ATTENTION

Due to limited cognitive capacity, consumers attend to only a small fraction of available stimuli. Attention depends on consumer state and goals (e.g., hunger, time pressure, budget). Selective attention is therefore influenced by sensory salience, such as contrasts in color, size, or smell, which help certain products stand out.



INTERPRETATION

Once attended to, sensory cues are interpreted based on prior experience and expectations, often using simple heuristics. These interpretations shape perceptions of quality, freshness, and value, influencing choice without the need for deliberate comparison.

SENSORY MARKETING STRATEGY

OVERVIEW

This section proposes a sensory strategy for Bergen Kaffebrenneri by triggering smell at the coffee shelf to influence quality perception and increase trial.

IMPACT

- Increase attention toward Bergen Kaffebrenneri at the coffee shelf
- Strengthen perceived quality and freshness through olfactory cues
- Increase purchase likelihood despite a higher price point

PURPOSE OF THE SENSORY-BASED INTERVENTION

Bergen Kaffebrenneri is a newer, premium-priced coffee brand sold at REMA 1000, which benefits from sensory differentiation. The degassing valve on the package aims to encourage consumers to engage with the scent at the point of purchase. By activating olfactory perception (smell), one of the strongest drivers of food and beverages (Holland et al., 2005), the brand can enhance perceived quality and freshness, evoke positive associations, and reduce uncertainty, thereby supporting rapid, low-effort decisions despite a price premium.

STRATEGY

Strategy to Increase Sales Bergen Kaffebrenneri

BKB

01

MAKE THE SMELL FEATURE OBVIOUS

Many shoppers won't notice the degassing valve, so the shelf needs a clear prompt, such as "Smell me," on the shelf tag or near the valve. Linking it to REMA 1000's "NYHET!" label makes it feel natural.

02

FRAME SCENT AS PROOF OF QUALITY

Because the brand is new and premium-priced, pair the smell moment with a short line about freshness, roast character, or bean quality to justify the price.

03

ENCOURAGE COMPARISON

Keep the three coffee bean variants BKB sells grouped together and add a cue such as "Smell all three · choose your favorite." This shifts the decision from price to preference.

04

TURN INTERACTION INTO PURCHASE

Add a brief nudge that links aroma to a "cafe at home" benefit and reduces hesitation among first-time buyers.

WHY THIS INCREASES SALES

In REMA 1000, coffee choices are often made quickly using simple cues rather than detailed comparisons. Prompting customers to smell the beans creates sensory and personal engagement, which research shows to guide quick, low-involvement grocery decisions (Krishna, 2012; Spangenberg et al., 1996). The sensory cue sends a credible quality signal, reduces uncertainty, shifts the decision from price to preference, makes it harder to put back, and increases the likelihood of purchase, especially important for a newer premium brand.



LIMITATIONS & RISKS



EXECUTION & MAINTENANCE

Degassing valves must consistently release a noticeable, pleasant scent. If aroma fades or turns stale, it could signal low quality rather than freshness.



SENSORY OVERLOAD IN-STORE

If the coffee shelf is near strong-smelling categories (bakery, cleaning products), the scent cue may be diluted or create an unpleasant mix.



CUSTOMER SKEPTICISM

Some shoppers may perceive "Smell me" prompts as gimmicky, particularly price-conscious customers who prioritize value over experience.



HYGIENE CONCERNS

Post-pandemic, some consumers may be reluctant to lean in and smell products on a shared shelf. Physical engagement with the valve could feel unhygienic.



SCALABILITY & COST

Rolling out across hundreds of stores requires consistent packaging quality, shelf placement agreements, and staff training, adding cost that may erode margins.



COMPARISON RISK

Encouraging shoppers to smell all three variants side by side could create decision fatigue, leading some to default to a familiar competitor brand.

LEARNING AND MEMORY

CONSUMER INSIGHT

Consumer Learning and Brand Knowledge

Consumers' understanding of the Oatly brand is built on learning processes that develop over time. This gathered knowledge influences the perception and the evaluation of the brand when consumers are purchasing items in a grocery store.



BRAND RECOGNITION

Built through repeated exposure to distinctive packaging, messaging, and shelf presence over time



LEARNING PROCESSES

Knowledge accumulated through classical conditioning, cognitive learning, and direct product experience



PURCHASE EVALUATION

Stored brand knowledge shapes in-store perception, evaluation, and ultimately the purchase decision

01

LEARNING PROCESS

Cognitive Thinking

One of the most important learning processes shaping consumers' perceptions of Oatly is cognitive learning, which involves actively processing information and developing beliefs about the brand. Oatly's communication and marketing strongly focus on sustainability and environmental impact. This is reinforced by Oatly's unconventional packaging, which challenges norms in the milk category and encourages consumers to process the brand's message.

In addition, Oatly's ad campaigns and website are eye-catching and thought-provoking with

messages that clearly convey the brand's viewpoint.

Through repeated exposure to Oatly's sustainability-focused messages, consumers may form stronger brand beliefs that Oatly is a more environmentally responsible brand in the milk-alternatives market than dairy milk. As this is also generally supported by research literature, consumers are more likely to store it as brand knowledge in addition to making the beliefs more accessible and stable over time. When consumers are in a grocery store, such as REMA 1000, this knowledge is retrieved, increasing the chances they will choose Oatly's products.



Through repeated exposure, consumers store sustainability beliefs as brand knowledge, making them more accessible at the point of purchase.

KEY INSIGHT

LEARNING AND MEMORY

02 LEARNING PROCESS Classical Conditioning

In addition to cognitive learning, a consumer's perception of Oatly is shaped by classical conditioning, a learning process that emphasizes the repeated association of stimuli. The goal of classical conditioning is to transfer the effect of a stimulus to another. In Oatly's case, the focus has been on associations with cafe culture and high-quality coffee. Cafes are thought of as places to relax and socialize with friends or family. Therefore, coffee consumption evokes positive feelings in most of the population, and research shows that caffeine, the main stimulant in coffee, can increase happiness (Hachenberger et al., 2025). Oatly links its products to these positive experiences by maintaining a strong presence in cafes, offering an oat-based milk alternative specifically made for baristas, and developing a tool on its website called Oatfinder, where you can locate cafes in your city that serve Oatly's oat-based milk.

CLASSICAL CONDITIONING PROCESS · OATLY & CAFE CULTURE



Key takeaway: Through both cognitive learning and classical conditioning, Oatly has built strong brand associations that influence consumers at the point of purchase. These learning processes work together to shape brand knowledge, reduce uncertainty, and increase the likelihood of choosing Oatly at REMA 1000.



MOTIVATION

CATEGORY ANALYSIS

Motivational Drivers Within the Milk Category

Milk is a staple product frequently purchased during everyday grocery shopping. Having examined how specific brands such as Oatly build associations through learning processes, we now turn to the broader motivational forces that drive Kristian's choice within the milk category as a whole, including whether those learned brand associations translate into actual purchase behaviour when competing against price, habit, and convenience. Although milk products are often perceived as similar across brands, there are several subcategories, such as plant-based alternatives and lactose-free milk. These differences influence how consumers' needs, goal conflicts, and perceived risks shape motivation in this category.



MOTIVATIONAL DRIVERS

Consumer Needs

Milk is often used in everyday situations, such as breakfast, cooking, and coffee preparation. For Kristian Eriksen, a time-constrained father of two, milk therefore serves a clear functional purpose in daily household routines. The dominant need in this category is **utilitarian**, meaning that decisions are primarily guided by functional benefits such as efficiency, reliability, and value for money (Batra & Ahtola, 1991).

In low-involvement and habitual product categories, such as staple foods, consumers often rely on simple cues, such as price and familiarity, when making decisions (Hoyer, 1984). Price becomes a salient cue because it signals efficient goal fulfilment in routine purchase situations. Lower-priced options within trusted brands are therefore likely to be preferred because they satisfy functional needs with minimal cognitive effort.

However, even utilitarian categories can activate additional motivations. **Symbolic needs** may emerge when personal values, such as environmental responsibility, become salient in the decision-making situation. Choosing plant-based alternatives can therefore function as an expression of responsible consumption. **Hedonic needs** may also influence decisions in certain contexts where sensory performance matters, such as when milk is used for coffee and taste or frothing quality become important (Batra & Ahtola, 1991).

✓ UTILITARIAN

PRIMARY

Efficiency, reliability, and value for money. Price and familiarity as key cues for routine decisions.

🛡️ SYMBOLIC

SECONDARY

Environmental responsibility and identity expression through plant-based choices.

☕ HEDONIC

CONTEXTUAL

Sensory performance such as taste and frothing quality, especially for coffee use.

Goal Conflicts

Consumers in the milk category may experience an approach-avoidance conflict when competing needs are activated simultaneously. For Kristian Eriksen, the central tension lies between price efficiency and value alignment. On one hand, he favors lower prices, routine-based decisions, and shopping efficiency, especially in a time-constrained family context. On the other hand, he may wish to avoid contributing to environmental harm or poor animal welfare, particularly when plant-based alternatives are visible on the shelf.

Because milk is purchased frequently on a routine basis, shopping trips are often time-sensitive. In these situations, cognitive resources are limited, increasing reliance on simple decision cues such as price and familiarity, which is typical for habitual grocery purchases (Hoyer, 1984). In contrast, avoidance goals, such as reducing environmental impact, require greater cognitive effort and long-term thinking. Acting on these goals demands reflection and self-control, especially when sustainable alternatives carry a price premium or when consumers face uncertainty about product performance or taste (Mitchell, 1999).



As a result, in everyday purchase situations, approach motivations related to price, habit, and convenience are more likely to dominate. Kristian is therefore more inclined to choose the familiar, cost-efficient option, even if it does not fully align with broader sustainability values. This dynamic illustrates how utilitarian motives and time pressure systematically reinforce price-based decisions in the milk category (Batra & Ahtola, 1991), whereas value-driven avoidance goals are more vulnerable to override in routine contexts.

Perceived Risk

Milk is a relatively low-involvement and frequently purchased product category. In such categories, perceived risk tends to be limited, particularly when product quality is standardized and well known (Mitchell, 1999). Because the Norwegian milk market is highly regulated, physical health risks are generally not perceived as a major concern among consumers.

However, plant-based alternatives may introduce performance and financial risk. Consumers may be uncertain whether the product will function properly for cooking or coffee preparation, thereby increasing perceived performance risk. Taste uncertainty may also arise, particularly in recipes where flavor neutrality is expected. In addition, plant-based alternatives are often more expensive than conventional milk, increasing financial risk if the product does not meet expectations (Mitchell, 1999).

These uncertainties can make plant-based alternatives appear more risky than regular cow's milk, which is associated with familiarity and predictable performance.



PERFORMANCE RISK

Uncertainty whether plant-based alternatives function properly for cooking, coffee, or recipes requiring flavor neutrality



FINANCIAL RISK

Plant-based alternatives carry a price premium, increasing the cost if the product does not meet expectations



HEALTH RISK

Norwegian milk market is highly regulated, so physical health risks are not a major consumer concern



CONVENTIONAL MILK · RIGHT CHOICE FOR KRISTIAN

Standardized quality, regulated market, familiar taste, predictable performance, lower price point

ATTITUDES

02

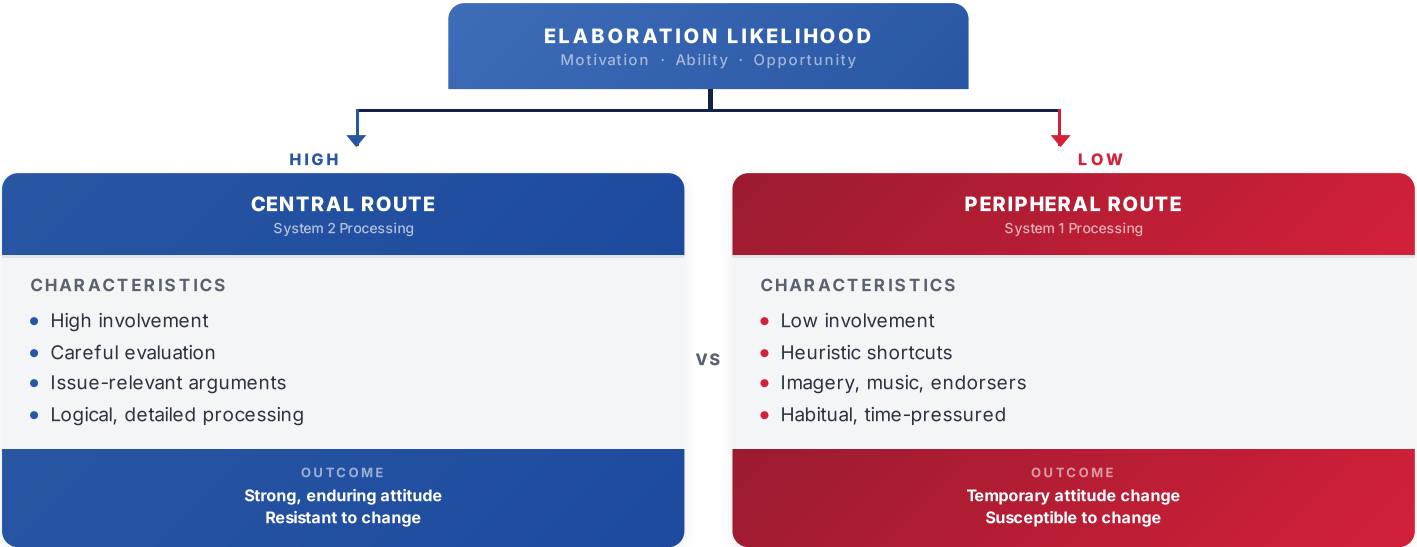
Assignment 2: Attitudes and Decision-making

Attitudes · ELM · Decision-making · Heuristics

FRAMEWORK

Elaboration Likelihood Model

The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) is a framework for persuasion that primarily focuses on two routes through which consumers can be influenced in their decision-making. One is the central route, which aligns with System 2 processing, and the other is the peripheral route, which aligns with System 1 processing. The route applied depends on the consumer's motivation, ability, and opportunity, and is determined by the overall elaboration likelihood. Elaboration means the extent to which the consumer scrutinizes the arguments presented in the persuasive communication (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Simply put, high elaboration indicates high consumer involvement, which falls under the central route. Coffee is a habitual, time-pressured, low-involvement purchase, meaning attitudes can be shaped without detailed product-relevant argument processing.



APPLYING ELM: THE EVERGOOD AD CAMPAIGN

Applying the ELM to the EVERGOOD ad campaign, the advertisement relies mostly on peripheral cues rather than logical arguments. This is unsurprising, since most attention-grabbing attempts go unnoticed or elicit low consumer involvement when the product falls under the peripheral category. As stated by Grimes (2008), "consumers making decisions under conditions of low involvement lack the motivation to actively seek and process detailed issue-relevant information, and instead rely on heuristics such as imagery, music, and endorser characteristics." Coffee is an everyday purchase, making it low-involvement, so the consumer typically follows the peripheral route.

The EVERGOOD advertisement specifically focuses on peripheral cues: upbeat music, an exciting chase, suits, close-up images of coffee beans, and brewing, all desirable associations captured through cinematic filming. The other focus is professionalism: well-dressed actors in a lab-like setting add precision to the brand image through peripheral processing. At the end, the protagonist returns for another cup, signaling loyalty through repeated exposure, which can lead to greater central processing and long-lasting purchase behavior (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986).

UPBEAT MUSIC
Emotional arousal and positive association

CHASE SCENE
Excitement and attention through fast-paced editing

SUITS & STYLE
Professionalism and quality signaling

COFFEE BEANS
Close-up product imagery and sensory appeal

BREWING
Ritual and craftsmanship through cinematic filming



Scan to watch ad

COGNITIVE SYSTEMS

Consumer decision-making in grocery retail

Consumer decision-making can often be understood through dual-process theory, which distinguishes between two cognitive systems: System 1 and System 2 (Kahneman, 2011). System 1 is fast, automatic, and relies on heuristics, while System 2 is slower and involves more deliberate reasoning. In grocery settings, many decisions default to System 1 due to low Motivation, Ability, and Opportunity (MAO) to process information carefully (Solomon, 2020). However, when perceived risk increases or decisions involve symbolic consequences, consumers are more likely to activate System 2. Therefore, it is necessary to assess which system is most likely to dominate within each specific product category and decision context.

 PRODUCT CATEGORY
Milk

PRIMARYLY SYSTEM 1

Understanding which cognitive system dominates is essential when analyzing grocery retail decisions. The milk category is typically low involvement, purchased frequently, and often driven by habit. For consumers like Kristian, milk is a staple integrated into established routines for breakfast, cooking, and coffee. Because it is bought regularly, repeated purchases reinforce habit formation and reduce the need for active evaluation over time (Wood & Neal, 2009). As a result, consumers are more likely to rely on simple cues such as brand familiarity or price when selecting milk.

From a MAO perspective, several factors support automatic processing in this category. Motivation to engage in detailed comparison is generally low, as perceived differences between conventional dairy brands are relatively small. In a highly standardized and regulated market, functional variation is limited, and consumers see little benefit in carefully comparing alternatives. Ability is often constrained by time pressure during routine shopping trips. This is particularly relevant for Kristian, who balances full-time work with the responsibility of caring for two young children, leaving him with limited cognitive resources for

deliberative choice. Furthermore, familiar store layouts and consistent shelf placement reduce consumers' need for extensive cognitive processing. Kristian can then navigate the store quickly and rely on familiar visual cues rather than actively evaluating alternatives. Consequently, the final choice is often guided by the first acceptable option rather than a careful comparison of alternatives.

Together, these conditions favor fast, low-effort decisions. Milk purchases are therefore primarily processed through System 1, where choices are guided by habit, brand familiarity, simple price cues, and packaging recognition rather than systematic attribute comparison. However, System 2 may occasionally be activated when consumers reconsider their routines, for example, when evaluating plant-based alternatives for environmental or ethical reasons, comparing nutritional attributes for their children, or reacting to new price promotions. Under normal shopping conditions, however, milk remains a habitual category; as long as the product meets basic expectations for taste, reliability, and price, Kristian is unlikely to reconsider his choice.

**MOTIVATION**
LOW
Small perceived differences in a standardized and regulated market

**ABILITY**
CONSTRAINED
Time pressure and work-family balance limit cognitive resources

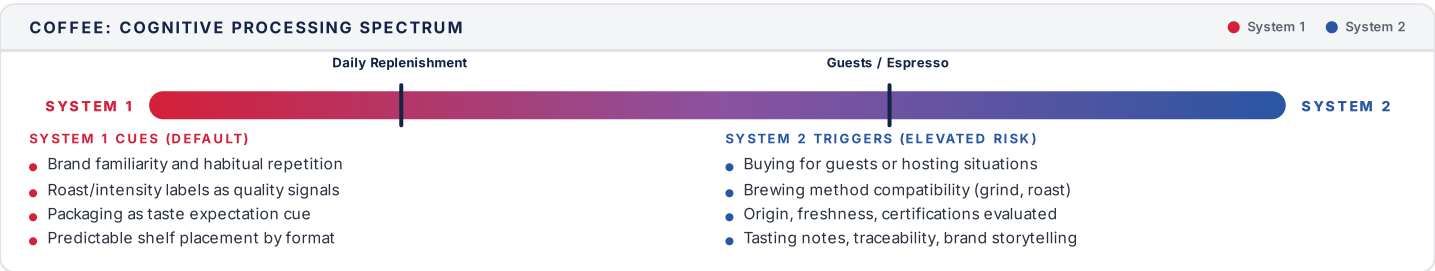
**OPPORTUNITY**
LIMITED
Familiar layouts reduce need for extensive cognitive processing

 PRODUCT CATEGORY
Coffee

PRIMARYLY SYSTEM 1

REMA 1000 offers a relatively classic, recognizable coffee assortment, with many familiar, frequently purchased alternatives. For many households, coffee serves as a routinized replenishment item: consumers arrive with a brand in mind and therefore quickly recognize the preferred option. In this context, choice is typically low-effort and guided by System 1. REMA's store environment further supports intuitive processing by lowering cognitive load: coffee is a stable category with predictable shelf placement and clear segmentation by format and brand, making the decision a recognition task rather than an evaluation task. Consumers can therefore rely on heuristics such as brand familiarity, habitual repetition, roast/intensity labels as simplified quality signals, and packaging as a cue for taste expectations. These cues work as mental shortcuts that enable fast selection with minimal deliberation (Kahneman, 2011).

However, coffee is also a category that can trigger System 2 when perceived risk or involvement increases. This shift often occurs when the consumer is buying for others, for instance, in situations regarding guests or where consumers face a host role, where social evaluation raises the cost of a "wrong" choice, or when the purchase moves into higher-stakes segments. Functional risk is also salient in coffee because satisfaction depends on compatibility with the brewing method: grind type, roast level, and bean quality can materially affect the outcome, especially for espresso. Under these conditions, consumers slow down and engage in more analytical processing, comparing alternatives and constructing justifications.



Instead of relying mainly on recognition and price, they evaluate more diagnostic attributes such as roast profile, origin, freshness/roasting cues, certifications, and brand values. Informational cues on packaging (tasting notes, traceability, roasting method, and brand storytelling) become decision inputs because they help reduce uncertainty and justify the upsell. In short, everyday coffee shopping tends to be System 1-driven by habit and recognition, but shifts toward System 2 when social, financial, or functional risks arise and when the consumer needs to justify a non-routine choice (Kahneman, 2011).

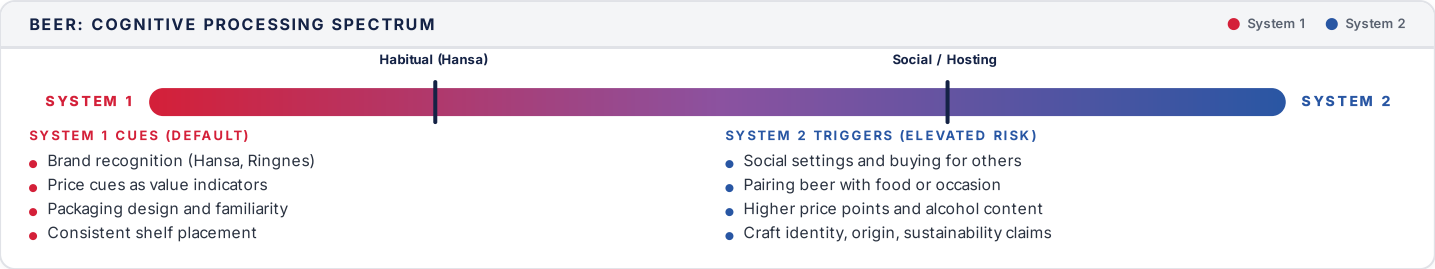
PRODUCT CATEGORY

Beer

PRIMARYLY SYSTEM 1

REMA 1000 offers a fairly typical and recognizable selection of beers, with many options familiar to consumers. In this category, choices are often made with little effort: consumers come with preferences that help them quickly recognize brands and use simple decision rules rather than engage in extensive comparisons. This is especially common when beer is a habitual purchase with low perceived risk, such as Kristian buying a Hansa. In such cases, REMA's merchandising supports System 1 decision-making by decreasing cognitive effort: consistent shelf organization, clear separation of beer as a distinct section, and predictable placement make choosing a beer feel like a routine selection rather than a major decision.

When the shopping environment treats beer as a default category and offers familiar cues, consumers tend to rely on mental shortcuts such as brand recognition, price cues as indicators of value, and packaging design. These cues serve as mental shortcuts that allow decision-making to happen quickly and with minimal thought (Kahneman, 2011). However, consumers do not always stay in System 1. When perceived risk increases, decision-making usually becomes more deliberate. Risk can rise for various reasons: for example, in social settings, buying for others, or bringing beer to a gathering where others will judge the choice.

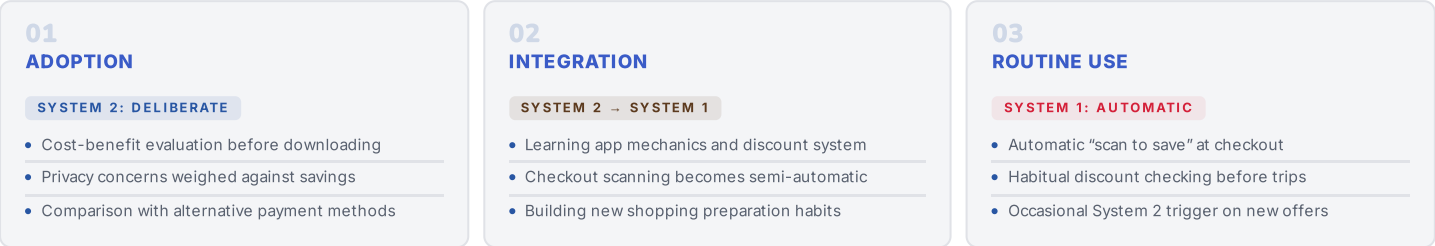


When consumers want to perform, wanting the beer to "fit" the food or occasion, or considering financial or health risks such as higher price points, higher alcohol content, or personal consumption goals, they are more likely to engage System 2. This slows down the process, prompting consumers to evaluate alternatives and justify their decision. Instead of mainly relying on recognition and price, they consider more diagnostic attributes like beer style, alcohol content, taste profile, brand values, authenticity (craft identity, local origin, sustainability claims), and sometimes informational cues on packaging (ingredients, brewing method, awards, or storytelling).

PRODUCT CATEGORY

The REMA 1000 App: Bridging the Systems

The REMA 1000 app cannot be classified as purely System 1 or System 2; its impact depends on the stage of interaction. To assess its cognitive role, it is necessary to distinguish between the initial decision to adopt the app and the decisions made during everyday use.



The adoption stage is primarily driven by System 2. Before downloading the app, consumers must evaluate whether the expected benefits outweigh the effort required for registration and the potential privacy concerns. Because the value proposition is based on accumulated savings and personalized discounts, the decision involves a forward-looking cost-benefit assessment. Consumers may also compare the app with alternative payment methods or loyalty programs. Evaluating these financial benefits and risks, therefore, requires deliberate reasoning, which is characteristic of System 2 processing. Consumers who perceive the savings as meaningful are therefore more likely to adopt the app despite the initial effort required.

Once the app becomes integrated into the shopping routine, the cognitive dynamics gradually shift toward System 1. Repeated actions in stable contexts often develop into habits that require little conscious deliberation (Rothman, Sheeran, & Wood, 2009). A clear example is scanning the code at checkout to

activate discounts and gain cashback. Initially, the consumer must remember to open the app and understand how the savings mechanism works. Over time, however, scanning becomes an automatic step triggered by the checkout situation itself. Rather than reassessing the benefit during every purchase, the consumer relies on a simple heuristic such as "scan to save."

For Kristian, the app may also influence planning before entering the store. Checking personalized discounts can become a habitual step when preparing a shopping trip. In this situation, he may quickly scan the app to identify relevant offers without engaging in detailed evaluation. However, a relevant discount can trigger analytical reasoning and result in a more deliberate decision. Because Kristian aims to balance household budgeting with efficient shopping, he may evaluate whether a discounted product should replace an item already on the shopping list or whether the offer justifies purchasing a larger quantity.

KEY INSIGHT

The app structures Kristian's shopping so that habitual, low-effort behaviors guide most decisions, while occasionally prompting System 2 evaluation when relevant offers appear.

DECISION RULES

Buying beer for a dinner party

Decisions that involve System 2 processing are typically characterized by more deliberate and high-effort evaluation, with consumers likely to apply explicit decision rules when comparing alternatives. The decision to purchase beer for a dinner party is likely to involve at least some rational consideration, as consumers engage in more deliberate evaluation before making a choice. Unlike habitual beer purchases for personal consumption, this situation involves social visibility and social risk, since the product choice may influence how others judge the consumer. When a purchase is socially visible and involves the risk of making an inappropriate choice, consumers become more motivated to carefully assess alternatives, which increases involvement and activates more deliberate System 2 processing (Kahneman, 2011).



SOCIAL VISIBILITY

Others will judge the beer choice at the dinner



SYMBOLIC VALUE

Choice signals taste, knowledge, and identity



CRAFT EXPANSION

Growing variety of styles and local brands in Norway



MULTIPLE CRITERIA

Taste, food fit, brand, and price all matter

This dynamic is reinforced by broader developments in the beer market. In Norway, demand for craft and locally produced beer has expanded the variety of styles and brands available to consumers, encouraging greater attention to attributes such as taste profile, origin, and brewing method (Euromonitor, 2025). At the same time, innovation in the category increasingly focuses on low- and non-alcoholic variants in response to growing demand from more health-conscious consumers (Euromonitor, 2025). As beer assortments become more diverse and differentiated, product choices increasingly carry symbolic value and can signal taste and knowledge in social settings.

Consumers may use a compensatory decision rule, such as the weighted additive rule, when evaluating beer alternatives for a dinner party. In situations where multiple product attributes are relevant, and consumers are motivated to make an appropriate choice, they tend to evaluate alternatives across several attributes and trade off their strengths and weaknesses (Bettman et al., 1998).

COMPENSATORY RULE
Weighted Additive Decision Matrix

In Kristian's case, taste profile is the most important attribute when evaluating beer alternatives, as flavor expectations strongly shape consumer preferences in beverage choices. In the context of a dinner party, food compatibility is also highly relevant, as consumers often seek beverages that complement the meal and enhance the overall dining experience. Brand reputation and price also play a role, as recognizable brands can reduce uncertainty in social settings, and price can serve as a proxy for perceived quality. Consumer decision research shows that when individuals evaluate products characterized by several relevant attributes, they often assign different weights to these attributes depending on the decision context (Bettman et al., 1998). Based on these considerations, we can assign different weights to the attributes and construct an attribute table to evaluate the available alternatives for Kristian.

Drivers	Weight	Hansa Fatøl	Frydenlund Fatøl	7 Fjell American Pale Ale
Price	7	10	8	6
Food fit	8	7	7	8
Brand reputation	7	10	6	10
Taste profile	9	6	7	8
Total Score (Weighted)		250	217	248



WEIGHTED ADDITIVE WINNER

Hansa Fatøl

The attribute table contains three beers: two regular and one premium craft beer. Using the compensatory decision rule, Kristian should choose Hansa Fatøl, as it scores the highest total weighted score. The beer's high scores in brand reputation and price compensate for its lower scores in food fit and taste profile.

250
POINTS

ALTERNATIVE RULES

Conjunctive Rule

Alternatively, Kristian may apply a non-compensatory rule, such as the conjunctive rule, where he establishes a minimum score for each attribute that the chosen alternative must meet. Alternatives that fall below any threshold are eliminated, regardless of how well they perform on other attributes. Kristian could demand a food fit score above 6, a brand reputation above 5 given the social setting, a taste profile above 8 as his most important attribute, and a price score above 5. Using these criteria, only the 7 Fjell APA remains, and should be his choice.

Attribute	Min. Threshold	Hansa Fatøl	Frydenlund Fatøl	7 Fjell APA
Taste profile	→ 8	6 ✗	7 ✗	8 ✓
Food fit	> 6	7 ✓	7 ✓	8 ✓
Brand reputation	→ 5	10 ✓	6 ✓	10 ✓
Price	> 5	10 ✓	8 ✓	6 ✓
Result		Eliminated	Eliminated	✓ Survives

NON-COMPENSATORY RULE

Lexicographic Rule

Lastly, if Kristian wants to make a quick decision, he could apply the lexicographic rule. When using a lexicographic decision rule, consumers rank attributes by importance and select the alternative that performs best on the most important attribute, without considering lower-ranked attributes unless alternatives are tied. The most important attribute for Kristian, when evaluating beer alternatives, is taste profile. He should therefore pick the alternative that scores the highest in this attribute, which is the 7 Fjell APA.

#1 TASTE PROFILE	#2 FOOD FIT	#3 BRAND REP.	#4 PRICE
Hansa 6 Frydenlund 7 7 Fjell APA 8 ★	Hansa 7 Frydenlund 7 7 Fjell APA 8	Hansa 10 Frydenlund 6 7 Fjell APA 10	Hansa 10 Frydenlund 8 7 Fjell APA 6

COMPARISON

Three Rules, Three Outcomes

01 WEIGHTED ADDITIVE COMPENSATORY	02 CONJUNCTIVE NON-COMPENSATORY	03 LEXICOGRAPHIC NON-COMPENSATORY
All attributes weighted and summed Strengths on one attribute compensate for weaknesses on another. Highest total weighted score wins.	Minimum thresholds per attribute Any alternative falling below any cutoff is eliminated, regardless of other scores.	Best on most important attribute Selects the best performer on the highest-ranked attribute. Taste profile ranked #1.
✓ Hansa Fatøl (250 pts)	✓ 7 Fjell APA (only survivor)	✓ 7 Fjell APA (taste: 8)

A key takeaway is that different decision rules yield different preferred alternatives, illustrating that consumer choice outcomes depend on the evaluation strategy applied. The weighted additive rule favors Hansa Fatøl due to its balanced performance across all attributes, while both non-compensatory rules favor the 7 Fjell American Pale Ale, either because it is the only alternative that meets all minimum thresholds or because it scores highest on the most important attribute.

Overall, consumers in this segment are most likely to apply a weighted additive decision rule, as the dinner party context requires balancing several important attributes rather than relying on a single criterion. However, non-compensatory rules such as the conjunctive or lexicographic rule may be applied under time pressure or when consumers wish to simplify the decision process. This illustrates how System 2 decisions may still vary depending on situational factors, even within the same purchase context.



KEY INSIGHT

The chosen decision rule shapes the outcome as much as the product attributes themselves. Different evaluation strategies applied to identical data produce different preferred alternatives, highlighting the importance of understanding how consumers process information in social purchase contexts.

SYMBOLIC NEEDS

Identity expression through consumption

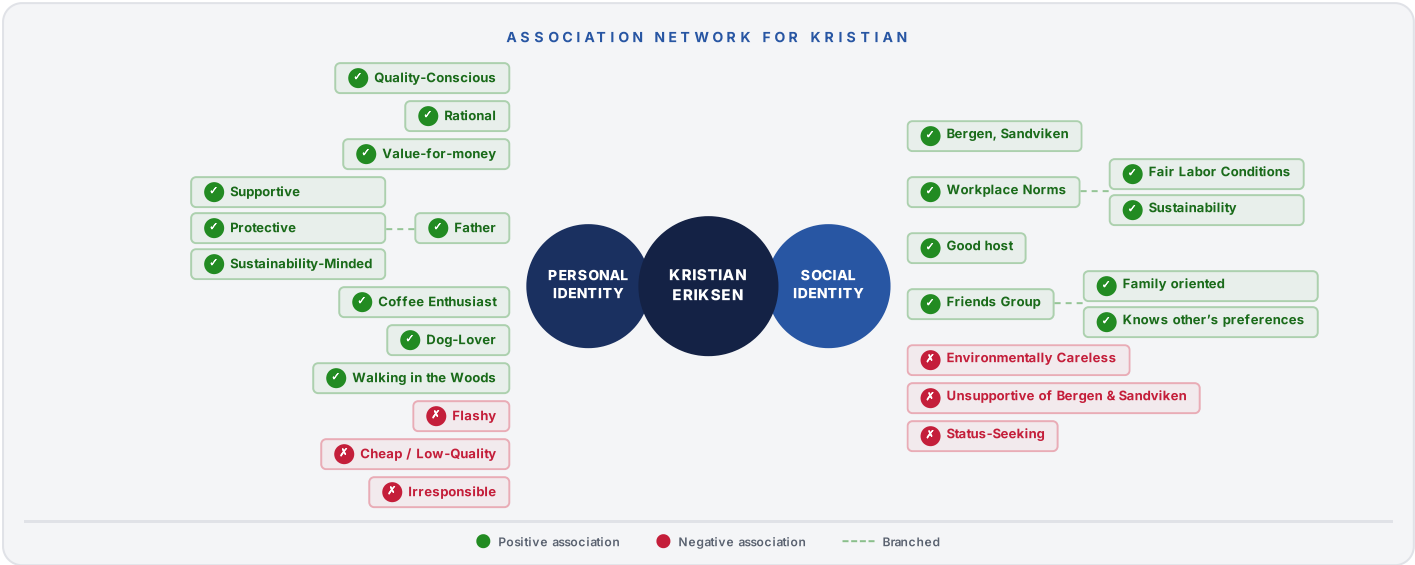
03

Assignment 3: Being and Belonging
Identity · Symbolic Consumption · Social Norms

“A man's self is the sum total of all that he can call his.”
James, 1890, as cited in Solomon, 2020

This idea reflects how individuals define themselves not only through beliefs and values, but also through the things they possess and consume. Products and brands can therefore function as symbolic resources through which consumers express aspects of their personal and social identity (Solomon, 2020). Although identity expression is often associated with visible products such as clothing or cars, it can also influence everyday consumption decisions. The following sections analyze how consumers' identities may shape purchasing decisions in routine consumption contexts.

To ground this analysis, the association network below maps the key personal and social identity associations for Kristian, highlighting both the values he identifies with and those he actively distances himself from.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Kristian's Identity at a Glance

Kristian's personal identity is shaped by values of quality, rationality, and getting good value for money. His role as a father is central, branching into being supportive, protective, and sustainability-minded. Lifestyle interests such as coffee, dogs, and nature reinforce an identity grounded in everyday authenticity rather than display. His negative associations (flashy, cheap, and irresponsible) reveal what he actively distances himself from, suggesting that consumption choices serve not only to express who he is, but also to signal who he is not.

On the social side, Kristian's identity is anchored in his Bergen and Sandviken community. His workplace norms extend into values of fair labor conditions and sustainability, while his friends group highlights a family-oriented and attentive social role. The negative social associations (environmentally careless, unsupportive of his local community, and status-seeking) further define boundaries that shape his consumption behaviour.



THEORETICAL FOUNDATION & WHAT FOLLOWS

According to Solomon (2020), consumers use products as **symbolic resources** to construct and communicate their sense of self. Kristian's association network illustrates how both personal values and social roles create a framework for everyday consumption. The following pages examine how this identity plays out across four product categories at REMA 1000: **milk** (parental and ethical identity), **coffee** (lifestyle and enthusiast culture), **beer** (social signaling in a regulated market), and **the REMA 1000 app** (digital loyalty as brand alignment).

MILK & IDENTITY

Symbolic consumption in everyday choices

The milk category has expanded beyond traditional dairy milk to include organic, lactose-free, and plant-based alternatives such as oat and almond milk (Sethi et al., 2016). This diversification introduces products that differ not only in functional attributes but also in the values they represent. Even routine grocery purchases can therefore function as symbolic expressions of consumer identity.

SYMBOLIC CONSUMPTION

How Milk Choices Signal Identity

**PARENTAL IDENTITY**
Self-concept & family role

As a father of two, Kristian's milk choices reinforce his identity as a responsible parent who prioritizes his children's health and nutritional development. Selecting conventional dairy milk for the household reflects a deliberate effort to meet perceived nutritional needs, linking everyday purchasing to the caregiving role central to his self-concept (Dror & Allen, 2014).

**ETHICAL VALUES**
Sustainability & animal welfare

Plant-based alternatives allow consumers to express environmental concern and align consumption with sustainability values. Research shows 28–37% of consumers accept price premiums for plant-based milk, suggesting these products carry value beyond their functional attributes (Zhang et al., 2023). For Kristian, this reflects his sustainability-minded orientation.

**SOCIAL SIGNALING**
Group belonging & lifestyle

Milk choices communicate social identity and group belonging. As a coffee enthusiast, Kristian's preference for specific milk types signals familiarity with barista culture. Choosing premium brands like Rørosmeieriet at REMA 1000 further signals preferences for quality and locality (Escalas & Bettman, 2005).

IDENTITY EXPRESSION

Milk as a Resource for Identity Signaling

As a father of two young children, Kristian shares the responsibility of providing food for his household. For many parents, food choices are closely tied to the role of caring for their children's health and development. Consumption decisions can therefore reinforce aspects of consumers' self-concept and social roles. Milk has long been a staple in many households and is frequently associated with children's growth and nutritional development (Dror & Allen, 2014). Choosing milk for the household may therefore allow Kristian to act in accordance with an identity as a responsible parent.

Milk choices may also reflect consumers' personal values and ethical considerations. Some individuals view everyday consumption as a way to align with concerns about environmental sustainability and animal welfare (Solomon, 2020). Empirical evidence shows that consumers with strong environmental concern are willing to pay price premiums for plant-based milk alternatives, with roughly 28–37% accepting higher price levels in willingness-to-pay experiments (Zhang et al., 2023).

Milk choices can also signal consumers' social identities and their desire to belong to particular groups. Consumption can communicate how individuals wish to be perceived by others and which lifestyles they identify with (Escalas & Bettman, 2005). In food consumption, certain products often become associated with specific communities or consumption cultures. For example, within coffee culture, hobby baristas often prefer milk types that complement espresso-based drinks, signaling their familiarity with coffee enthusiast practices.

At the same time, retailers such as REMA 1000 offer a wide assortment of milk products, including premium alternatives like Rørosmeieriet. Choosing such products may signal preferences for quality, locality, or artisanal food culture. Through visible consumption choices, consumers can communicate preferences to others. In this way, milk choices function not only as expressions of personal values but also as signals of social identity.

28–37%
of consumers accept price premiums for plant-based milk alternatives
Zhang et al., 2023

IDENTITY SIGNALING PROCESS



Consumers express identity through product choices that carry symbolic meaning beyond functional value.



Even routine milk purchases carry symbolic weight. Kristian's choices reinforce his parental identity by providing nutritious options for his children, reflect his ethical values through openness to sustainable alternatives, and signal social belonging through coffee culture and premium brand preferences. What appears to be a simple grocery decision is, in practice, a layered act of identity expression where personal values, family roles, and social aspirations converge at the shelf.

KEY INSIGHT

COFFEE & IDENTITY

How identity shapes consumer behaviour towards coffee

Coffee is often a habitual, low-involvement purchase, but it is not purely a utilitarian product because it conveys the consumer's identity through factors such as origin, quality, roast, legacy, and sustainability. It can serve as a symbolic resource through which consumers express both personal and social identity. Kristian Eriksen's coffee purchase at REMA 1000 may therefore communicate taste, values, and a sense of belonging, in addition to fulfilling a functional need.

PERSONAL IDENTITY

Quality, Values, and Fatherhood

Reflecting his personal identity, Eriksen wants to see himself as someone who values quality while also being rational and value-conscious. The previously discussed olfactory cue intervention with a degassing valve from Bergen Kaffebrenneri could not only reduce uncertainty at the point of purchase but also reinforce Kristian's identity as someone who makes informed decisions and cares about quality. His preference for quality may lead him to prefer slightly premium brands over the cheapest option while avoiding excessive branding costs, such as those associated with status-driven brands.

Where a part of his personal identity is to be one who makes good choices for the family or friends group. Although Bergen Kaffebrenneri is not the cheapest option, it signals uniqueness and authenticity without appearing flashy or conspicuous.

His decision may also be influenced by his identity as a father, his concern for labor conditions, and his commitment to sustainability. By choosing a sustainable, ethically sourced product, he reinforces his self-image as a father who makes responsible choices for the family and cares for future generations. This aligns well with Bergen Kaffebrenneri's values, which emphasize fair trade and ethically and sustainably sourced coffee.



BERGEN KAFFEBRENNERI

BRAND PERSONALITY (AAKER, 1997)

SINCERITY	COMPETENCE	SOPHISTICATION	EXCITEMENT	RUGGEDNESS
- Local - Authentic - Genuine - Crafted	- High Quality - Expertise - Trustworthy	- Refined Flavor - Stylish Design	- Bold - Inspiring	- Nordic - Nature-Inspired

SOCIAL IDENTITY

Community, Norms, and Visible Consumption

Kristian's coffee choice may also reflect his social identity. By buying local brands and supporting the community, he could strengthen his feeling of belonging to the community ingroup (Escalas & Bettman, 2005). In addition, as a public-sector worker, Kristian may be influenced by his workplace's norms, such as environmental responsibility and fair labor conditions. Further, coffee is often consumed in social settings, at work, or with guests, which makes the purchase decision more salient than most, underscoring the impression-management aspect. In social settings where purchase behavior is visible, research shows that consumers prefer costlier 'green' options to signal status through altruism, willingness to pay for others' benefit, more specifically conspicuous conservation (Griskevicius et al., 2010). These factors shift the coffee purchase decision from a mainly utilitarian one to an act of extending his personal and social identity, guided by shared norms and roles.



KEY INSIGHT

Coffee transforms from a habitual purchase into an identity statement. Bergen Kaffebrenneri aligns with Kristian's personal values of quality and responsibility, while its local origins and ethical sourcing reinforce his social identity as a community-minded, environmentally conscious consumer.

BEER & IDENTITY

Symbolic consumption in a regulated market

Even routine beer purchases can function as symbolic expressions of consumer identity. Alcoholic beverages are often visible consumption products that can communicate taste, lifestyle, or cultural preferences to others in social situations.

NORWEGIAN MARKET CONTEXT

Regulation Shapes Identity Cues

In Norway, however, these identity expressions occur within a highly regulated market. Supermarkets may only sell beer with an ABV of up to 4.7%, and promotional coupons or price discounts on alcohol are legally prohibited (Norwegian Alcohol Act, 1989). In addition, alcohol advertising is largely restricted, meaning that brands cannot rely on traditional advertising campaigns to shape consumer perceptions.

As a result, consumers cannot rely on marketing communication in the same way as in many other product categories. Instead, beer choices are more strongly influenced by cues available at the point of purchase, such as brand familiarity, packaging design, prior experience, and label information.

**ABV LIMIT 4.7%**
Supermarkets restricted to low-alcohol beer only; stronger products sold at Vinmonopolet

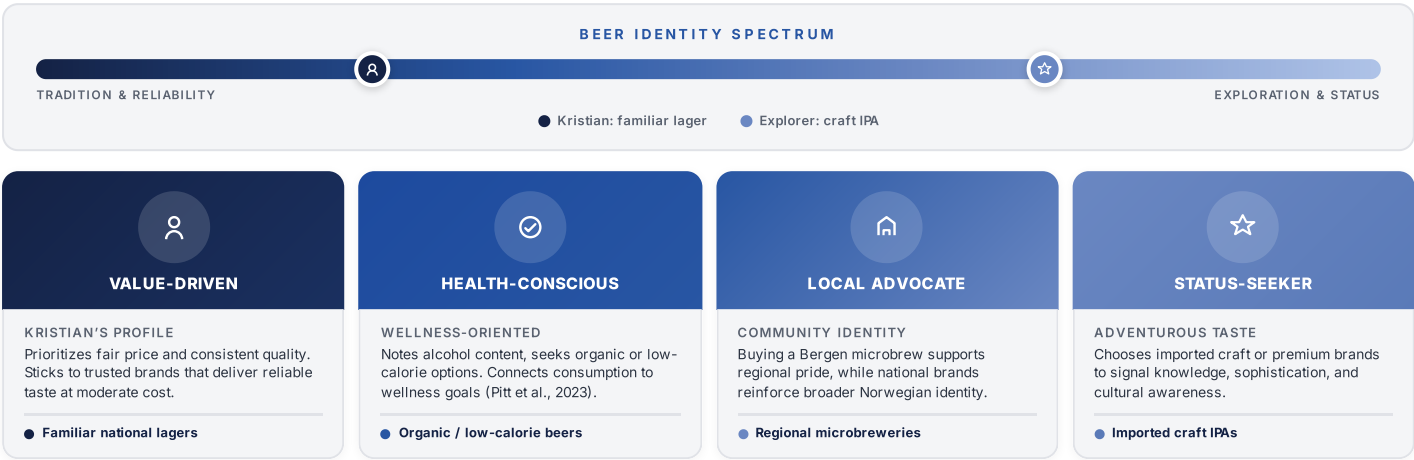
**NO PROMOTIONS**
Price discounts and coupons on alcohol are legally prohibited

**AD RESTRICTIONS**
Brands cannot use traditional advertising to shape consumer perceptions

IDENTITY EXPRESSION

How Beer Choices Signal Identity

Even within these constraints, beer brands carry symbolic meanings that consumers may use to express aspects of identity (Solomon, 2020). For Kristian, choosing a familiar lager may reflect a preference for reliability and tradition, whereas an acquaintance's choice of an imported craft IPA might signal a more adventurous, status-seeking identity. Even in routine grocery shopping contexts, beer choices can signal subtle differences in consumers' taste and lifestyle preferences.



Beer choices may also signal consumers' social identities and their desire to belong to particular groups. Consumption can communicate how individuals wish to be perceived by others and which lifestyles they identify with (Escalas & Bettman, 2005). In many social contexts, alcoholic beverages function as visible consumption products that allow consumers to signal taste, knowledge, or cultural preferences. While milk choices often reflect personal values and self-concept, beer choices may communicate identity more explicitly to others through visible consumption.

These identity expressions arise despite the functional nature of grocery shopping. Even routine supermarket decisions may be motivated by

consumers' desire to act in ways consistent with salient aspects of their self-concept (Belk, 1988; Solomon, 2020). Marketing researchers note that people prefer products that reflect their social identity and feel more attached to brands they perceive as part of "us" (Bartoli et al., 2022). Whatever their motives, Norwegian beer shoppers weave personal and social identity into their choices, using brands and product attributes as symbolic cues (Solomon, 2020).

Of these archetypes, Kristian most closely aligns with the Health-Conscious Explorer. As a responsible father open to quality alternatives, non-alcoholic craft options could resonate with his values.

**KEY INSIGHT**

Even within Norway's strict alcohol regulations, beer choices serve as symbolic identity cues. Kristian's habitual lager choice reflects preferences for familiarity and value, while other consumers use beer to signal health consciousness, regional pride, or cultural sophistication.

APP & BRAND VALUES

Digital loyalty as identity expression



REMA 1000 BRAND PHILOSOPHY

“The simplest is often the best”

REMA 1000's loyalty app personalizes savings by discounting products the consumer habitually purchases, reinforcing the brand's core values of simplicity, efficiency, and low prices.

DIGITAL IDENTITY

Mobile App Use and Brand Values

The REMA 1000 app personalizes savings by discounting products the consumer habitually purchases. By actively choosing to engage with this app, Kristian aligns himself with the brand's perceived values of simplicity, efficiency, and low prices. Just as choosing a particular store communicates something about who a consumer is, engaging with a retailer's digital ecosystem extends this identity alignment into daily routines. The app's streamlined interface reinforces Kristian's self-concept as a practical, value-driven consumer, and using it signals congruence between his personal identity and REMA 1000's brand personality (Solomon, 2020).

SOCIAL IDENTITY & SELF-CONCEPT

Two Sides of App Engagement as Identity Expression

The decision to use or reject the REMA 1000 app can function as a symbolic expression of identity in itself, reflecting how consumers wish to be perceived and which values they prioritize. According to the social identity model, consumption choices can express facets of identity including group membership, lifestyle signaling, and value-driven self-concept (Solomon, 2020). Two contrasting identity positions emerge around app engagement.



THE DIGITAL ADOPTER

Approach motivation — embracing the app

Using the REMA 1000 app can signal that the consumer is technologically aware, modern, and in step with digital trends. For Kristian, adopting the app reflects an ideal self-concept as an efficient, organized, and forward-thinking individual. It communicates competence in managing household resources through digital tools and aligns with a broader cultural narrative of embracing innovation in everyday life.

From a social identity perspective, app adoption signals group membership within digitally engaged, trend-conscious consumers and reinforces brand community belonging (Escalas & Bettman, 2005).

GROUP MEMBERSHIP IDEAL SELF LIFESTYLE SIGNAL



THE PRIVACY PROTECTOR

Avoidance motivation — rejecting the app

Conversely, a consumer may deliberately reject the app as a form of identity expression. Norwegian grocery chains, including REMA 1000, hold significant market power, and some consumers view loyalty apps as instruments through which corporations collect personal data and reinforce exploitative pricing dynamics. Refusing the app can therefore express opposition to perceived corporate control over everyday consumption.

For a privacy-conscious consumer, this rejection reflects an actual self-concept rooted in autonomy, data protection, and critical awareness of commercial surveillance (Solomon, 2020).

VALUE EXPRESSION ACTUAL SELF ANTI-CORPORATE STANCE

APPROACH-AVOIDANCE GOAL CONFLICT



APPROACH

Desire to appear modern, tech-savvy, and efficient. Belonging to the REMA brand community and benefiting from personalized savings.

IDENTITY TENSION

VS

GOAL CONFLICT



AVOIDANCE

Desire to protect personal data, avoid supporting exploitative corporate practices, and maintain autonomy over consumption decisions.

Kristian may experience tension between wanting to signal digital competence and modernity while simultaneously avoiding being perceived as careless with personal data or uncritically supportive of corporate data collection practices (Solomon, 2020).

Moreover, frequent app use identifies Kristian as a loyal REMA 1000 customer. By repeatedly using the app and organizing his grocery purchases on the platform, Kristian reinforces his relationship with the retailer and signals his loyalty to the brand. Digital brand interactions that become part of everyday routines can strengthen consumers' psychological connection to a brand and reinforce identity alignment with its values (Bartoli et al., 2022).

Consumers form stronger attachments to brands they see as reflective of their identity (Bartoli et al., 2022). By curating his grocery basket through

the REMA 1000 app, Kristian signals support for the values REMA promotes, such as local sourcing and quality products. Yet this identity expression may be tempered by an awareness that embracing the app also means accepting a degree of corporate data collection, creating an ongoing negotiation between the consumer's ideal and actual self-concept.

For Kristian, the app's transparency and price-comparison tools match his value-conscious side, while loyalty tracking supports his role as a responsible family provider.



KEY INSIGHT

The REMA 1000 app creates an approach-avoidance conflict in identity expression. Using the app signals digital competence and brand community belonging, while rejecting it can express data privacy values and opposition to corporate market dominance. This tension illustrates how even routine digital consumption tools can become sites of identity negotiation.

SOCIAL NORMS

BEHAVIOURAL INTERVENTION

Why Social Norms Matter in Low-Involvement Decisions

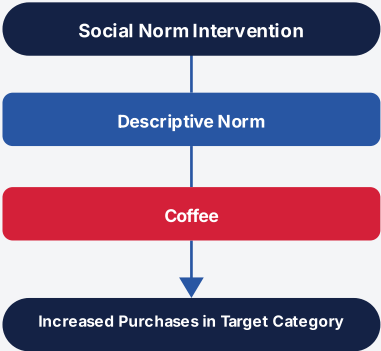
Supermarkets can leverage social norms to nudge customers towards desired purchasing behavior. Research suggests that for low-involvement behaviors such as everyday food purchases, normative influences play a significant role in shaping consumer decisions (Saleem et al., 2025). The following section analyses and explains how normative appeals can influence customers' purchasing decisions at REMA 1000.

APPLICATION

REMA 1000 Social Norm Intervention Framework

Huitink et al. (2020) found that placing a green inlay with normative messages (e.g., 'Most customers pick at least seven vegetables') in shopping carts significantly increased vegetable purchases in a Dutch supermarket. This suggests it is worth exploring how REMA 1000 can leverage social norms to increase spending in relevant product categories.

SOCIAL NORM INTERVENTION FRAMEWORK FOR REMA 1000



A descriptive norm intervention applied to the coffee category to nudge consumer behaviour at the point of purchase.

Descriptive norms communicate what most people typically do in a given situation. These messages leverage the human tendency to conform to perceived majority behaviour, making them effective nudges for routine, low-involvement purchases like coffee, where social cues at the point of purchase can meaningfully influence which product ends up in the basket. The goal of the intervention is to drive sales of Bergen Kaffebrenneri coffee at REMA 1000.



KEY INSIGHT

By implementing normative messaging in-store and through the REMA 1000 app, the retailer can subtly guide customers towards target brands in the coffee category using a descriptive social norm appeal.

COFFEE INTERVENTION

Descriptive norm intervention to nudge coffee purchases



COFFEE NUDGE

Descriptive norm intervention for Bergen Kaffebrenneri



PROPOSED DESCRIPTIVE NORM MESSAGE

“The majority of customers at this REMA 1000 who try Bergen Kaffebrenneri **stick with it**”

Placed directly in the coffee aisle at REMA 1000 to activate the descriptive norm at the exact moment of decision.

THE NORM MESSAGE

Why Descriptive Norms Work for Coffee

Coffee is a particularly suitable category for this kind of intervention. As a low-involvement habitual purchase, customers rarely engage in deliberate evaluation when choosing coffee, making them receptive to simple social cues at the shelf. Instead of making a direct quality claim, the message communicates that customers who have tried Bergen Kaffebrenneri are satisfied enough to keep buying it, signalling quality and consistency through social proof.

According to the focus theory of normative conduct, norms are most influential when they are visible at the moment consumers are deciding (Cialdini et al., 1990). Placing the message in the coffee aisle ensures the norm activates exactly when the customer is making their choice.



FOCUS THEORY OF NORMATIVE CONDUCT

Norms are most influential when they are visible at the moment consumers are deciding. Placing the message in the coffee aisle ensures the norm activates during the purchase decision.

Cialdini et al., 1990



SYSTEM 1 DECISION CUE

Descriptive norms signal what other shoppers typically choose, serving as a quick heuristic for low-involvement habitual purchases like coffee.

IN-STORE APPLICATION

Provincial Norms & Placement

Mentioning the specific store in the message draws on the concept of provincial norms. Descriptive norm messages are most effective when the reference group closely matches the individual's immediate situation (Goldstein et al., 2008). By setting the reference group as customers at *this specific REMA 1000*, the message creates a social comparison with people who shop in the same place and face the same product selection.

PROVINCIAL NORM EFFECT

When the customer is standing in the coffee aisle, that reference group feels close and relevant, which strengthens the persuasive effect of the norm. The specificity of “this REMA 1000” makes the social proof feel immediate and personally applicable.

Goldstein et al., 2008



KEY INSIGHT

Positioning a **customer retention norm** at the point of purchase leverages System 1 processing and provincial norms to make social proof feel **immediate and personally relevant**.

COFFEE NUDGE

Risks and benefits of the descriptive norm intervention

IMPACT

Risks



DATA INTEGRITY AND BRAND TRUST

A central requirement for the descriptive norm intervention is that the claim must be supported by verified data. If the message turns out to be false or misleading, customers may lose trust in REMA 1000 as a brand, a consequence that could extend beyond coffee sales and could drive customers toward competitors such as Kiwi. Restoring brand trust once it is damaged is a slow and costly process. Even if the data is accurate, some customers may perceive the nudge as a deliberate attempt to manipulate their choices, generating skepticism toward the store.



SUPPLIER RELATIONS

There is potential tension with competing coffee brands stocked in REMA 1000. If those brands feel they are being deprioritized, it could complicate margin negotiations and affect supplier relationships.



FINANCIAL PRESSURE ON CUSTOMERS

The higher price point of Bergen Kaffebrenneri means the nudge could create financial pressure on some customers, effectively steering them away from more affordable alternatives and reducing their purchasing power for other groceries.

IMPACT

Benefits



ETHICAL SOURCING AND CONSUMER WELLBEING

Bergen Kaffebrenneri sources its coffee through direct trade with farmers (Bergen Kaffebrenneri, n.d.), and research on ethical food consumption suggests that simply perceiving a product as consciously produced can increase consumer wellbeing (Apaolaza et al., 2018). Assuming that the claim is accurate, the norm message can reduce the customer's decision effort. By providing them with knowledge about how other customers feel about Bergen Kaffebrenneri, they can simplify their choice.



HEALTH BENEFITS

Coffee consumption in general has been associated with reduced risk of diseases such as Parkinson's disease and heart disease (Wachamo, 2017), and Bergen Kaffebrenneri's roasting process is relevant here too, as studies have found that roasting can increase the antioxidant levels in coffee beans, with the majority of tested varieties showing stronger antioxidant activity after roasting (Priftis et al., 2015).



SUPERIOR TASTE AND EXPERIENCE

The quality of the roasting process also affects taste directly. Research shows that properly roasted coffee free of defects is significantly preferred by consumers (Giacalone et al., 2019), suggesting that high-quality roasters like Bergen Kaffebrenneri can offer a more complex aroma profile compared to mass-produced alternatives, resulting in a more enjoyable experience overall.



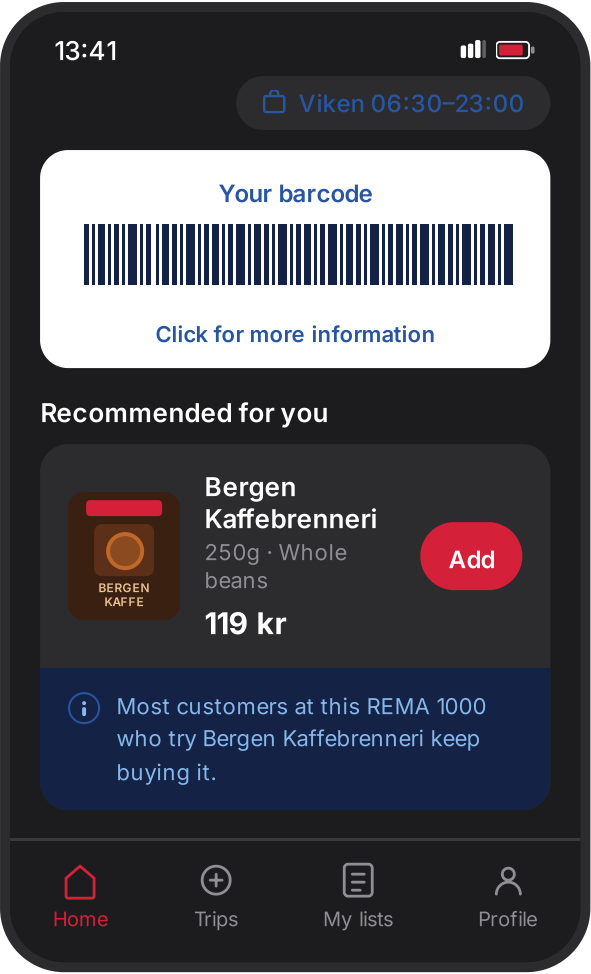
KEY INSIGHT

The intervention's risks centre on **data accuracy and brand trust**. Its benefits extend beyond sales, offering customers genuine value through ethical sourcing, health advantages, and a **higher quality product experience**.

COFFEE NUDGE

Alternative implementation: the REMA 1000 app

IN-APP NUDGE MOCKUP



ALTERNATIVE APPROACH

Implementing the Nudge in the App

TARGETED REACH

While the in-store shelf tag relies on the customer noticing the message at the right moment, the REMA 1000 app enables a more targeted approach. By using purchase history, REMA 1000 can identify customers who regularly buy coffee at the store but have not yet established a brand preference, and direct the nudge specifically at them. This precision increases the likelihood of trial, as the message reaches consumers whose purchase behaviour indicates openness to switching (Goldstein et al., 2008).

TRADEOFF: REACH

The in-store shelf tag is visible to every customer who passes the coffee aisle, while the app nudge is limited to customers who have the app installed and engage with it regularly, which is a smaller group.

TIMING AND PERSONALISATION

The app allows REMA 1000 to send the nudge at a deliberate moment, such as when the customer is browsing the app before a shopping trip, increasing the likelihood that the message is registered before the customer reaches the coffee aisle. The app also opens up the possibility of personalizing the message, for example by referencing the customer's own purchase pattern, which could make the nudge feel more directly relevant than a generic shelf tag.

LIMITATION

Reduced Point-of-Purchase Activation

The in-store message derives its effectiveness from activating at the point of purchase, where the customer is already engaged in a decision and social cues can be processed automatically through System 1 (Kahneman, 2011). In the app, the nudge is received earlier and through a different cognitive pathway: the customer must encode the message, retain it in working memory, and retrieve it later at the coffee aisle. This temporal separation introduces a memory-dependent step that reduces the immediacy of the normative cue. Furthermore, the store-specific reference group that strengthens the in-store message loses salience in the app context, as a reference to fellow customers at a particular REMA 1000 location carries less weight when the consumer is not physically present in that store (Goldstein et al., 2008). If both channels are used simultaneously, repeated exposure to the same message may trigger reactance rather than compliance (White & Simpson, 2013), potentially undermining the perception of the nudge as informative and connecting to the manipulation concerns discussed in the risk section. The app-based delivery also requires more advanced implementation than the in-store shelf tag, including data infrastructure, customer segmentation, and interface design.



KEY INSIGHT

The app offers **precision and timing control** but sacrifices reach and point-of-purchase activation, the core mechanism that makes the in-store nudge effective.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

Key takeaways and implications for REMA 1000

This paper analyzed consumer decisions at REMA 1000 across the categories milk, beer, coffee, and the REMA 1000 app through the perspective of internal influences, attitudes and decision-making, and identity. A social norm intervention was developed for the coffee category, demonstrating how descriptive norms can nudge purchasing behavior. The following are the key takeaways.



TAKEAWAY 1 – PERCEPTION

Sensory cues shift decisions from price to preference

- Olfactory cues (e.g., smelling coffee beans) reduce uncertainty and signal quality at the point of purchase
- The proposed Bergen Kaffebrønneri strategy shows how a low-cost sensory intervention can increase trial of a premium product



TAKEAWAY 2 – DECISION-MAKING

Most grocery decisions are System 1 → but context triggers System 2

- Routine purchases (milk, habitual beer, daily coffee) default to fast, heuristic-driven choices
- Social visibility, unfamiliarity, or higher stakes (e.g., dinner party beer) activate deliberate evaluations (System 2)
- REMA 1000 should support both: simplicity for routine shopping and diagnostic cues (ethics, norms) for high-involvement decisions



TAKEAWAY 3 – IDENTITY & NORMS

Everyday purchases still express identity → normative nudges can activate it

- Habitual choices such as milk, beer, and coffee can still function as symbolic resources for expressing personal values and social belonging
- A descriptive norm campaign for Bergen Kaffebrønneri coffee demonstrates how highlighting peer behavior can steer purchasing decisions
- Messages displaying trends lets REMA 1000 nudge customers without relying on promotions or price discounts



LOOKING AHEAD

From in-store nudges to steering behavior through the REMA 1000 app

- Purchase data enables effective normative nudges and evaluate sensory strategies
- This allows delivering the right nudge at the right time to the right consumer, increasing intervention effectiveness
- Combining digital personalization with in-store cues can be a scalable, effective and low-cost growth lever

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